

Problem Solving in Services

Case studies · student questions

Scenarios are hypothetical; brand names are used only as settings.

CASE 1

Same coffee, different experience: a Starbucks store in Colaba vs Kings Circle

Two Starbucks stores in Mumbai use the same menu, the same beans, the same machines and the same recipe cards. The Colaba store gets consistently good reviews for taste. The Kings Circle store gets repeated complaints: “coffee tastes bitter”, “not like the one in town”, “inconsistent – good one day, bad the next”.

The regional manager’s first reaction is: “The Kings Circle baristas need retraining.”

Information available to you

- Kings Circle has higher barista attrition. Four of its seven baristas joined in the last three months.
- Its peak (8–10 am, office and college crowd) is sharper than Colaba’s, which has steadier tourist traffic through the day.
- The two stores source water differently. The espresso machines were serviced on different schedules.
- Kings Circle does not record extraction time or shot weight. Colaba’s senior barista “just knows by looking”.
- Complaints come mostly during morning peak hours.

Questions

- 1 Write a clear problem statement for this case. What is the defect, where does it occur, when, and how would you measure it?
- 2 The manager has already decided on the cause (training). Why is jumping to a solution risky? Which problem-solving discipline guards against it?
- 3 List at least five possible causes. Organise them using an appropriate root-cause tool.
- 4 What data would you collect to find out which causes are real? Design a simple data collection plan.
- 5 How would you capture what Colaba’s senior barista “just knows” and make it standard across stores?
- 6 Once fixed, how would you make sure the taste stays consistent week after week?
- 7 **Which lean or problem-solving tools would you apply at each stage, and why?**

CASE 2

A Lean Six Sigma project at a fast food chain

A fast food chain has 40 outlets across Maharashtra. Leadership is worried about three signals:

- Drive-thru and counter waiting times have risen, and customers are leaving the queue.
- Food waste at closing time is high on some days, while items run out on others.
- Order accuracy complaints (wrong item, missing item) have increased on delivery apps.

You have been hired as a Lean Six Sigma Green Belt to run **one** project over 12 weeks. The CEO wants “all three fixed”.

Questions

- 1 The CEO wants all three problems fixed in one project. How would you respond? How would you choose which problem to take up first, and what criteria would you use?
- 2 For your chosen problem, draft the key elements of a project charter: problem statement, goal, scope, and what is out of scope.
- 3 Who is the customer in each of the three problems? What is “critical to quality” for them?
- 4 Map the high-level process for your chosen problem from start to end.
- 5 How would you measure the current performance? What is a “defect” and what is an “opportunity” here?
- 6 Which parts of the problem are about **waste and flow**, and which are about **variation**? How does this change your choice of tools?
- 7 After the project team moves on, how would you make sure the improvement holds across all 40 outlets?
- 8 **Walk through the phases you would follow. Which lean or problem-solving tools would you apply in each phase, and why?**

CASE 3

A Zepto dark store

A Zepto dark store in Andheri West serves a 2–3 km radius and promises delivery in about 10 minutes. It stocks around 5,000 items in a compact space. The store has pickers, packers and a fleet of delivery riders.

Operations data from the last month shows

- Order-to-dispatch time varies widely: some orders are packed in 2 minutes, others take 7.
- “Item not available” substitutions are frequent, even when the system shows stock.
- Pickers walk long, criss-crossing routes, especially for orders mixing chilled, frozen and dry items.
- Evening peak (7–10 pm) sees riders waiting at the store for orders, while at other times packed orders wait for riders.
- Mispicks (wrong variant or size) cause returns and refunds.

Questions

- 1 Break the customer’s 10-minute promise into stages. Where would you start looking for delays, and how would you find the slowest stage?
- 2 How would you study and visualise pickers’ movement? What would you look for in the result?
- 3 Why might the system show stock that pickers cannot find? List possible causes and how you would verify them.
- 4 How would you decide where each of the 5,000 items should be placed in the store?
- 5 Riders wait for orders at peak, and orders wait for riders off-peak. What does this tell you about matching capacity to demand?
- 6 How would you reduce mispicks without slowing pickers down?
- 7 What daily visual measures would you put up for the store team?
- 8 **Which lean or problem-solving tools would you apply to each of these issues, and why?**

CASE 4

Customised jewellery: the client rejects the finished piece

A boutique jewellery brand makes customised pieces: engagement rings, heirloom redesigns and bridal sets. The process is:

enquiry → consultation → sketch/CAD approval → advance payment → manufacturing by a karigar (artisan) → finishing → delivery

The brand has had several recent cases where a client rejected a finished piece, saying “this is not what I imagined”. In one case, a client approved the CAD render on WhatsApp. On delivery, she said the stone looked smaller and the band looked thicker than she expected. The piece had to be partly remade. That cost gold loss, labour and a three-week delay before a wedding.

Other facts

- Consultations are done by the founder or one sales associate, with notes kept informally.
- CAD renders are shared as phone images. There is no physical sample or wax model at approval.
- The karigar works from the CAD and verbal instructions. Some design details change along the way.
- There is no written sign-off on final dimensions, stone size or finish.

Questions

- 1 Write a problem statement. Is this a manufacturing defect, a communication defect, or something else? Justify your answer.
- 2 Using a root-cause tool, identify why the client’s expectation and the final piece did not match. Go at least five levels deep on one cause.
- 3 At which stages can a gap open up between the client’s expectation and the final product? Map them.
- 4 What is the cost of one rejection to the business? Include costs that are not obvious.
- 5 How would you design the approval step so that a mismatch is caught *before* metal is cast?
- 6 How would you make sure what the client approved is exactly what the karigar makes?
- 7 How could the brand find out whether this is a one-off or a repeating pattern?
- 8 **Which lean or problem-solving tools would you apply, and why?**